



IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Science fiction, fantasy

DIRECTOR

Georges Méliès

WRITERS

Georges Méliès, from novels by Jules Verne and H. G. Wells (all uncredited)

STARS

Georges Méliès, Bleurette Bernon, François Lallement, Henri Delannoy

BEFORE

1896 Méliès's short movie *Le Manoir du Diable* (*The Devil's Castle*) is often credited as the first horror movie.

1899 *Cinderella* is the first of Méliès's movies to use multiple scenes to tell a story.

AFTER

1904 Méliès adapts another Jules Verne story with *Whirling the Worlds*, a fantasy about a group of scientists who fly a steam train into the sun.

LABOR OMNIA VINCIT

A TRIP TO THE MOON / 1902

As its title suggests, the 12-minute-long movie *A Trip to the Moon* (*Le Voyage dans la Lune*) is a fantastical account of a lunar expedition. A group of scientists meets, a huge gun is constructed, and astronauts are blasted to the moon, where they fall into the hands of the moon-dwelling Selenites.

Chorus girls line up to fire the Monster Gun that will blast a spaceship to the moon. Méliès's overblown theatrical style keeps the action more absurd than heroic.

They are brought before the King of the Selenites, but manage to escape. They return to Earth, where a parade is held in their honor and an alien is put on display.

Magic tricks

Some pioneers of the cinema, such as the French Lumière Brothers, saw the new medium as a scientific breakthrough, a means of documenting reality. Frenchman Georges Méliès, the director of *A Trip to the Moon*, however, recognized it as a new way of performing magic tricks.

